

Core Elements of a Healthy Dietary Pattern:

The Dietary Guidelines for Americans emphasizes meeting nutritional needs primarily from nutrient-dense foods and beverages across four core life stages:

1. Vegetables of all types: Dark green, red and orange, legumes (beans, peas, lentils), starchy vegetables, and other vegetables.
2. Fruits: Especially whole fruits (fresh, frozen, canned, or dried without added sugars).
3. Grains: At least half of total grain intake should be 100% whole grains (such as whole wheat bread, oats, brown rice, and quinoa).
4. Dairy and Fortified Alternatives: Fat-free and low-fat (1%) milk, yogurt, cheese, and fortified soy beverages.
5. Protein Foods: Lean meats, poultry, eggs, seafood (targeting 8 ounces per week for adults), beans, peas, lentils, nuts, seeds, and soy products.
6. Oils: Plant oils (canola, corn, olive, soybean, sunflower) and natural oils in seafood and nuts.

Quantitative Daily Dietary Limits:

To prevent chronic non-communicable diseases, the Guidelines establish specific numeric limits on components of public health concern:

1. Added Sugars:

- Less than 10 percent of total calories per day starting at age 2.
- Avoid foods and beverages with added sugars for infants and toddlers under age 2.
- Major sources include sugar-sweetened beverages, baked goods, and dairy desserts.

2. Saturated Fats:

- Less than 10 percent of total calories per day starting at age 2.
- Replace saturated fats (butter, lard, palm oil, coconut oil) with unsaturated fats.

3. Sodium:

- Less than 2,300 milligrams (mg) per day for adults and adolescents aged 14+.
- Even lower limits apply to younger children (1,200 mg for ages 1-3; 1,500 mg for 4-8; 1,800 mg for 9-13).

4. Alcoholic Beverages:

- Adults of legal drinking age can choose not to drink or limit intake to 2 drinks or less per day for men, or 1 drink or less per day for women.